

# This Year's El Niño Is Breaking Records

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Scientists say this year's El Niño is already the strongest ever recorded, based on daily ocean temperatures. It may get even stronger.

An El Niño is a natural **climate pattern**. It happens when part of the Pacific Ocean near the **equator** gets warmer than normal. That warm water sends lots of heat into the air. This can change weather around the world, bringing **droughts**, floods, heat waves and storms.

By September 21, the ocean there was 3.08 degrees Celsius (5.54 degrees Fahrenheit) warmer than average. "It has been a **remarkable** event," said NOAA scientist Nathaniel Johnson. He thinks it will **peak** in the next few months.

NOAA has not officially called it a record yet, because it uses a newer way to measure. By that measure, the El Niño of 1997 and 1998 is still stronger, for now.

El Niños usually last about a year. Afterward, an opposite pattern called **La Niña** often follows.

## Word Treasure

**climate pattern** -- A climate pattern is a change in ocean and air that keeps coming back and affects weather.

**equator** -- The equator is an imaginary line around the middle of Earth.

**droughts** -- Droughts are long times with very little rain.

**remarkable** -- Remarkable means unusual and worth noticing.

**peak** -- The peak is the strongest point of something.

**La Niña** -- La Niña is the opposite of El Niño, when the same ocean area gets cooler than normal.

## Background you need

El Niño happens every few years when part of the Pacific Ocean gets warmer than usual. The Pacific is so big that its extra heat can change rain and storms in many countries. Scientists use thermometers on buoys and satellites to measure the ocean's temperature.

## Break it down

**WHO:** Scientists, including NOAA scientist Nathaniel Johnson

**WHAT:** This year's El Niño is the strongest ever recorded by daily ocean temperatures

**WHERE:** The Pacific Ocean near the equator

**WHY:** The ocean there is much warmer than normal and sends lots of heat into the air

## Why it matters

A strong El Niño can change the weather where you live, bringing more rain, dry spells or storms.

## Test what you remember

**1. What is an El Niño?**

- ☐ (A) A new island
- ☐ (B) A natural climate pattern
- ☐ (C) A type of fish
- ☐ (D) A kind of storm cloud

**2. Which ocean gets warmer during an El Niño?**

- ☐ (A) The Arctic Ocean
- ☐ (B) The Atlantic Ocean
- ☐ (C) The Indian Ocean
- ☐ (D) The Pacific Ocean

**3. How much warmer than average was the ocean by September 21?**

- ☐ (A) 10 degrees Celsius
- ☐ (B) 30 degrees Celsius
- ☐ (C) 3.08 degrees Celsius
- ☐ (D) 1 degree Celsius

**4. Who called it "a remarkable event"?**

- ☐ (A) A student
- ☐ (B) NOAA scientist Nathaniel Johnson
- ☐ (C) A weather reporter in Paris
- ☐ (D) An astronaut

**5. Which El Niño is still stronger by NOAA's newer measure, for now?**

- ☐ (A) The El Niño of 1997 and 1998
- ☐ (B) The El Niño of 2020
- ☐ (C) The El Niño of 1950
- ☐ (D) None

**6. What often comes after an El Niño?**

- ☐ (A) La Niña
- ☐ (B) An earthquake
- ☐ (C) Another El Niño the next day
- ☐ (D) A snowstorm everywhere

Answer key (try the quiz first!): 1: B 2: D 3: C 4: B 5: A 6: A

**MY THOUGHTS (at least 20 words):**